

Seeking Constantine

A sequence of poems
[inspired by the poetry of](#)
Constantine P. Cavafy

As translated by **Rik Roots**

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... να μη ζητήσουνε να βρουν ποιος ήμουν ...

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The Hidden Things

(After Constantine Cavafy's [*Κρυμμένα*](#))

From all that I've done, from what I have said,
let them not parse that effort to find me.

An obstacle held there; it transformed
my actions, my habits of life.

An obstacle stood there, stopped me,
caught words when I would speak.

My most unnoticed dealings
and my most hidden writing –
only from there will they feel me.

But perhaps it is not worth it, to pay
so much care, such effort, to analyse me.

And after – in that most perfect community –
some other me, made as I'm made, will surely
appear and push beyond the limits, and freely.

The Dangerous Ones

(After Constantine Cavafy's [*Τα επικίνδυνα*](#))

Said Myrtías (a student from Syria
in Alexandria at the time of those co-kings
August Constans and August Constantius,
partly pagan, experimenting Christian):
*"Strengthened by inquiry and reflection,
I'll not fear my urges like a coward.
I'll give my body to these pleasures,
these dreamed-of indulgences
these dared, erotic desires,
these blood-led lustful passions with
no fear, because when my will determines –
for I have the will, strengthened
as I am by reflection and inquiry –
in these critical moments I'll find
my spirit, once more, ascetic ..."*

The Windows

(After Constantine Cavafy's [*Ta παράθυρα*](#))

In this dark apartment, where I pass
the heavy days, I wander up and down, around,
to find the windows. For when open
one window will give me consolation.
But the windows are hard to find, or
I cannot place them. And maybe better I don't.
Perhaps the light will bring a tyranny.
Who knows what new things it would show.

The First Step

(After Constantine Cavafy's [*Το Πρώτο Σκαλί*](#))

Young Eumenes was complaining
one day, to the poet Theocritus:
*"I've been writing for two years now
and I've completed just one idyll.
It's the only proper thing I've finished.
It belittles me to see how high
– so tall – the poetry ladder is,
and from this first rung where I stand
I see no way to go up. It drains me of joy."*

And Theocritus said: *"These words of yours
are stray words, blasphemous even.
If you know you're on the first step
then you must be proud and happy.
This step where you stand is no little thing;
it is a glorious step you have taken.
You know, even this first solid step
is far beyond the crowds below.
For just climbing onto the ladder
earns you the right to know that you are
a citizen in the City of Ideas.
It is difficult to step into the city
and rare indeed to be claimed by it.
In that city's Agora sits a host of lawmakers
who see through all but the true adventurer.*

*Here's where you've arrived; it is not little:
what you've achieved deserves its glory!"*

For the Shop

(After Constantine Cavafy's [*Tou Mayaζiou*](#))

He wraps them with neatness and care
in some green and precious silk.

From rubies, a rose; from pearls, a lily.
From amethysts, violets. As he judges,

he wills it: his eye crafts them in beauty, not nature
as seen or studied. He'll keep them in the safe,

examples of his bold and capable work.
In the shop, as a buyer enters, he picks

others from cases, sells them – famous finery:
bracelets, chains, necklaces, rings.

Desires

(After Constantine Cavafy's [Επιθυμίες](#))

Like beautiful, stilled bodies who failed to age
and laid to rest, with tears, inside a bright mausoleum,
with roses by their heads and jasmine at their feet –
such did these desires look like when they passed
without fulfilment: with not one of them granted
the pleasure of a night, or a soft-lit morning.

Far Away

(After Constantine Cavafy's [*Μακρὰ*](#))

I'd like to relate this memory...

But it seems erased now... gone from recollection –
for it nests far away, in my young adolescence.

Skin layered from jasmine...

That August – *was it August?* – that evening...

I barely see the eyes now, they were, maybe, violet...

Ah, yes – violet, sapphirine violet.

Days of 1901

(After Constantine Cavafy's [*Μέρες του 1901*](#))

This was what was notable about him:

that in all his dissolute grace
and his wide learning in love,
despite all his familiar
harmonies of stance and age,
there were instants – of course
very rare – when an outline escaped
of flesh near intact.

The beauty of his twenty-nine years,
so tempered by pleasure,
offered up an unbalanced reminder:
an adolescent – ungainly in parts – in love
for the first time gives up his pure form.

Days of 1908

(After Constantine Cavafy's [*Μέρες του 1908*](#))

That year he found himself without work:
He lived off the cards,
the backgammon, recycled day-loans.

Work was offered, three pounds a month,
attending to needs in a stationery store.
He had refused it without hesitation.
He didn't chase it: a salary was not sought,
young with sufficient learning, twenty-five years old.

Two, maybe three shillings a day he earned; he wasn't winning.
The things a lad learns from playing cards and backgammon,
in the neighbourhood cafes, the popular ones:
no matter how smart he played, poor chances were waiting.
The loans, they came and remained.
Rarely was the pound found, more often half,
once it scraped down to the shilling.

Every few weeks, sometimes more,
as if fleeing from a torture of a sleepless night,
he cooled off in the baths, a morning swim.

His garb was a frayed mess.
He wore the same outfit all the time,
cinnamon faded clothes.

A summer day in nineteen oh eight:
an image caught and kept, a rightful pleasure,
the patch-bleached cinnamon cloth gone.

That caught-kept memory protected him
from when he was browning, when he was shedding
his sweat-worn shirt, his patched undercloth.
And he remained naked: complete, impeccable; a miracle.
His hair lifted up and combed;
his limbs a little sunburned
from the morning nudity in the baths, on the beach.

Days of 1896

(After Constantine Cavafy's [*Μέρες του 1896*](#))

His humiliation was complete. His interests in love
both immoral and despised
(though natural) was the cause:
society was so curt.

He gradually lost his little money;
following in turn, his reputation.

He was nearing thirty with not a year
of work to his name, as far as was known.

At times he had cash earned from
exchanges that earned shame.

A lad become a man whom, if you were seen with him
too often, well – the rumours would seep.

It's not that, though. It doesn't sit right.

It deserves more, that memory of his beauty.

There's another consideration which, when considered –
it seems, worthy: it seems, simple and genuine –

a child within love, beyond honour
and position posed without question
from pure flesh from pure pleasure.

His face was failed? But it is society
which seems so curt that sees only face.

One Night

(After Constantine Cavafy's [*Μία Νύχτα*](#))

The room was poor and filthy
hidden above the questionable taverna.
From the window, a view of an alley
in its narrowness and litter. From below
came a drift of workers' words
raised in chatter over cards.

And there in the hired, humble bed
I held a body for love, I touched lips
thickening pink in their intoxication –
flushed to ruddy drunkenness, that even now
as I write of it, all these years later
in this lonely home, I feel drunk again.

Days of 1903

(After Constantine Cavafy's [*Μέρες του 1903*](#))

I don't see them anymore – they're lost already ...
the poetic eyes, the wan
face ... in the street's twilight ...

I don't see them – picked up purely by chance,
I gave them up so easily
and then, for want, wanted them back.
The poetic eyes, the wan face,
I don't see those lips anymore.

I Went

(After Constantine Cavafy's [Ενήγδα](#))

I do not stall. I loosen completely and go.
Into indulgencies, perhaps half real,
half-caught in my head, and still –
I move into the well-lit night.
And I drink the strong wines as folk
brave in their pleasures do drink.

Candles

(After Constantine Cavafy's [Κεριά](#))

The days yet to pass stretch before us
like a column of candles in ranks –
golden and warm, delicate candles.

The days that are gone stay behind us,
a sad series of snuffed candles:
those closest still let drift smoke,
cold candles, melted and twisted.

I do not want to see; their forms sadden me,
it saddens me more to recall that first light.
I look ahead to the still lit candles.

I do not want to look back, lest I be scared
by how quickly the dark ranks lengthen,
how fast the dead candles multiply.

The City

(After Constantine Cavafy's [*Η Πόλις*](#))

*You said: "I will go to another land, another sea.
Another city will be found, better than this one.
All of my efforts, each of them writes a doom;
and this heart of mine – as if it's dead – buried.
How long will my mind stay in this wasting state?
Whatever I turn my eyes to face, wherever I look
I see the charred remains of my life here:
so many years I spent ruining, destroying it."*

You'll never find another land, another sea.
The city, it follows you. You'll return to its streets
unchanged. It's in these quarters you'll grow old
and in these solid houses that you'll turn white.
You'll always come to this city. For beyond – don't hope –
there's no ship for you, there's no road.
Just as you've worked to ruin your life here
in this home, its wreckage spreads the world over.